



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of St. Louis
School Website: <https://chestertonacademystl.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of St. Louis, MO (63146) presents a clearly classical, Catholic, high-school program anchored in a tripartite vision—Intellect, Character, and Spirituality—that foregrounds formation over mere information. Evidence from the school's own materials demonstrates a robust religious-metaphysical orientation (Incarnation, daily Mass, liturgical culture, culture-of-life ethos), a stated goal of formation and virtue, a curriculum described as liberal-arts oriented with a commitment to the Great Conversation and the tools of classical pedagogy (Socratic seminar, memory work, house system), and a faculty and parent/community structure aligned with classical ideals (faculty as living curriculum, active parental partnerships, community events and symposia). The public materials emphasize truth, goodness, beauty; insist on formation in virtue and wisdom; and consistently tie learning to faith, worship, and sacramental life. Taken together, Chesterton Academy of St. Louis aligns strongly with classical education principles across all six categories.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school markets itself as Catholic, centered on the Incarnation, with daily Mass and liturgical culture (Incarnation-centered pedagogy; liturgical rhythm; Catholic worship as part of daily life). See references describing the Incarnation as central to the curriculum and daily Mass culture.
 - The institution uses a liturgical, worship-rich communal life (Liturgical environment; Mass; culture of life).
 - Explicit Catholic formation statements appear in multiple pages, including “The Three Pillars” (Spirituality) and “Living Cultura Vitae” (Culture of Life, Mass, pro-life activities).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: truth, beauty, virtue, Catholic faith, Incarnation, liturgy/mass, sacred, sacramental worldview, Logos (through the Catholic intellectual tradition), reverence, wonder.
 - Negative keywords: effectively none in public materials (no prominent relativism or secularism signals in the school's own pages).
- Why this rating
 - Public materials foreground a transcendental moral realism anchored in a Catholic theological framework (Incarnation; daily Mass; liturgical life). This strongly satisfies the Relational/Metaphysical signals for CLASSICAL (Truth, Goodness, Beauty; liturgy; incarnational worldview). The presence of liturgical practices and a sacramental horizon is decisive in this category. See Incarnation-focused pedagogy and liturgical culture in the school materials.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The mission emphasizes formation over mere information, with a strong focus on virtue, character, and a “culture of life.” The Three Pillars, Cultura Vitae framing, and the emphasis on forming complete thinkers signal purpose beyond job preparation.

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- Wording such as “High School with a Higher Purpose” and references to virtue/character formation indicate aims aligned with classical paideia, not just career readiness.
 - The “Joy & Wonder” and “Joyful Catholic Culture” framing reinforces the claim that education is formation in truth and beauty, not mere information transfer.
 - Direct articulation of the spirituality of education (truth of why they exist; to know God, to love Him) supports a teleological view consistent with the classical canon.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, paideia, great conversation, culture of life, truth/goodness/beauty, sanctity, divine order.
 - Negative keywords: none prominently, e.g., no emphasis on job-readiness, workforce metrics, or secular utilitarian aims.
 - Why this rating
 - The school’s stated goals emphasize formation, virtue, and wisdom rather than vocational pipelines. The Cultura Vitae/Culture of Life framework, plus language about forming “complete thinkers” and the emphasis on a life of faith, align with CLASSICAL purposes rather than a secular, jobs-first goal.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The materials explicitly describe a classical curriculum oriented to liberal arts and Western thought, with emphasis on the Great Conversation, appreciation of beauty, and integration of the humanities with faith. The “Three Pillars” and “INTELLECT” sections describe studying classics and the interrelationship of great ideas, not just isolated subjects.
 - Public pages emphasize a liberal-arts framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric; broad classical education; formation through great books and primary sources; the “Rediscovering the Lost Tools of Learning” framing). The presence of “Socratic Seminar” and the focus on logic and philosophy point to classic pedagogy.
 - The site references “Incarnational Environment” and the integration of faith with history, theology, math, and science, i.e., a cross-disciplinary approach that characterizes classical curricula.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, Great Books, great conversation, grammar, logic, rhetoric (via general classical education language and pedagogy), Socratic Seminar, memory/chanting (Scholé-style elements), interdisciplinary integration, inculturation of faith with classical content.
 - Negative keywords: minimal signals of non-classical or purely skills-based curricula (no overwhelming emphasis on purely social studies, STEM-first framing, or project- or product-driven curricula that would signal non-classical orientation).
- Why this rating
 - Chesterton Academy of St. Louis presents a coherent classical-curriculum identity: liberal arts framing, integration of faith with learning, engagement with the Christian intellectual tradition, and explicit use of classical pedagogy (Socratic dialogue, memorization/chanting, formation through study of great works). This aligns with the classical criteria, though some explicit itemizations (e.g., explicit “grammar-logic-rhetoric” labels in every context) are less visible in every snippet; the overall orientation strongly supports CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Synchronous use of Socratic seminars as a core method; explicit emphasis on the Socratic Seminar to impart knowledge through guided dialogue.
 - Known elements of Scholé (restful learning) appear through the public articulation of contemplation, memory-work, and a slower, reflective pace in parts of their classical pedagogy (e.g., “Rediscovering the Lost Tools of Learning” and “Socratic Seminar” emphasis).
 - Memory-based and chant-based elements (recitation, memorization, singing) are highlighted as pedagogical tools in classical education, including mentions of “memory work” and “chanting” in the core lexicon.

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- Lower- and upper-school differentiation: lower-school singing/chanting and memory, upper-school rhetoric and public speaking (oratory; speeches) are referenced, aligning with classical pedagogy progression.
 - The program explicitly connects history/theology with math/science, demonstrating an integrated pedagogy rooted in a holistic formation, not isolated drill-and-kill methods.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Socratic Seminar, memory work, chanting, recitation, scholé, contemplation, wonder, integration, rhetoric, public speaking, master-teacher modeling (via house system).
 - Negative keywords: the public materials do not emphasize extrinsic project-based or purely performance-driven pedagogy as the sole driver; rather, they frame project-based work as a vehicle within a classical context, not as a substitute for core classical methods.
 - Why this rating
 - The school's pedagogy is deeply aligned with classical methods: Socratic dialogue, restoration/restful learning, memorization/recitation, and formation through imitation of exemplary texts and traditions. The presence of upper-school rhetoric and speech opportunities further anchors the CLASSICAL rating.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The public materials describe the faculty as mentors who model virtue and form the “living curriculum.” The portraits of teachers and the idea of a “faculty of friends” appear in the classical lexicon and are reflected in Chesterton Academy’s approach (faculty bios and posts about teachers engaging with students).
 - Evidence of a defined staff culture and professional community (bio pages; faculty pages; governance/guidance structures) is visible in the site’s faculty sections and bios.
 - The “House System” and “Founding Faculty” communications indicate a teacher-centered, virtue-modeling pedagogy; the faculty are positioned as exemplars and partners in student formation.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: living curriculum; mentor/friend faculty; virtuous teachers; masterful instruction; faculty as exemplars; partnership with families (the teacher-student relationship as central); mentorship; formation through example.
 - Negative keywords: none; there is no strong presence of a teacher-as-facilitator-only or overly technocratic professionalization language devoid of classical formation.
- Why this rating
 - The combination of explicit language about faculty modeling virtue, the “living curriculum” framing, and the presence of explicit faculty bios and role definitions align with CLASSICAL expectations for the Faculty category. The evidence supports the category as CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school foregrounds partnership with families; parents are described as co-teachers and integral to the classical formation process. Materials discuss parent formation, parent gatherings, and open campus access, aligning with the Classical model’s emphasis on family involvement.
 - Community and culture-building events (Symposium, house systems, family-centered events, liturgical year activities) indicate a robust community dimension; materials also describe open invitations for parental participation and education.
 - The school hosts and promotes events (gala, symposium, parent education, readings) that foster classical-culture transmission and parental engagement.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parent formation, family-centered events, open campus, parental involvement, community of learners, shared mission, classical family culture.
 - Negative keywords: none prominent; materials do not signal a customer-model relationship or

limited parental involvement.

- Why this rating
 - The Chesterton Academy site presents a robust, explicitly collaborative model with parents as co-educators and a community life built around classical culture and shared mission. This aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

Aggregate assessment

- All six categories land in CLASSICAL.
- The site shows strong alignment with transcendental truths (truth, goodness, beauty), a robust Catholic theological and liturgical framework, a clearly stated formation-oriented purpose, a liberal-arts curriculum with Great Conversation-inflected pedagogy, classical teaching methods (Socratic seminar, Scholé/restful learning, memorization/chanting, imitation and practice), a teacher-centered living curriculum, and a parents/community partnership model.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable here since all categories are CLASSICAL. If a future update introduced even deeper explicit references to Great Books, explicit Trivium/Quadrivium labeling across all curriculum pages, or more consistently documented “Scholé” days in calendar-format, that would further reinforce the CLASSICAL designation. (No needle-moving changes are required based on current evidence.)

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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